

BOOKS

VENICE REVISITED

It would be idle to speculate on what may have caused, in the present historical and cultural situation of Italy, a flourishing of "local" studies; the quality and scope of "local" traditions amply justify an interest in such studies at any time, and preserve them from suspicions of provincial chauvinism. Venice is, of course, an obvious instance. Recently two publications have been brought out, or rather initiated, as useful for an organized knowledge of Venetian history and literature as any that have so far appeared in our century. The first is a history of Venice, *Storia di Venezia* (Venice: Centro internazionale delle arti e del costume, vol. I, 1956) which will eventually comprise 16 volumes, under the general editorship of Roberto Cessi. The second is an anthology of Venetian lyric poetry, *Il fiore della lirica veneziana*, edited by Manlio Dazzi (Venice: Neri Pozza, vols. I and II, 1956), to be completed by two further volumes probably within the current year.

Not only local subjects, then, but also local publishers. The "International Centre of Arts and Costume," publisher of the first work, has its Venetian

seat in the newest of the great palaces on the Grand Canal, the 18th-century Palazzo Grassi; it is a generously endowed institution with manifold activities (e.g., in the theatre). The scholars who under its auspices have undertaken this new history of Venice, obviously intend to do, around the middle of our century, what the historian Romanin did, around the middle of the nineteenth, with the 10 volumes of his classic *Storia documentata di Venezia*.

The publisher of the other work reviewed here, Neri Pozza, is very possibly the most intelligent and courageous new publisher to appear in Italy during the postwar period. Though he publishes also fiction and poetry (for instance the original edition of Montale's latest book of poems, *La bufera e altro*), his present important trend is toward philology and criticism; in fact, he seems partly to inherit, at an almost opposite end of the peninsula, some of the traditions of the illustrious house of Laterza.

The first volume of the *Storia* is concerned with the ages "from pre-history to history" and includes four sections: a general one on natural environment; a second one covering

the "paleo-Venetian," pre-Roman, period; a central one, written by the general editor himself, Roberto Cessi (the greatest living authority on early Venetian history), titled "From Rome to Byzantium;" and finally a review of archaeological materials, by Giovanni Brusin, "Roman and Early Christian Monuments." In other words, all of this first volume is occupied by the pre-history and early history of the territory before Venice itself came into existence. The fascination of this study is obvious to anyone, even, so to speak, poetically; the geographical configuration of the Venetian territory, described in the early part of the book, and especially certain aspects of lagoon landscape, which are in some ways untouched today, suggest a mixture of continuity and mystery which is part of the unique attraction of the place. Indeed many of the problems handled in the historical sections of this volume are characterized by their hopeless insolubility; "Venetian" history, even of the Roman and early Christian periods, often presents a series of enigmas somehow held together by hypothesis. In spite of this situation, or, in fact, partly because of it, this area and period — when Rome was declining and Venice itself had not yet appeared — offer even to the general reader and interested visitor an extraordinary example of the varied complexity in the formation of Italian history. From this first volume of the quite profusely illus-

trated *Storia di Venezia* one gathers the impression that after quantities of partial studies (the bibliographies to each chapter are very inclusive) a general gathering of materials was overdue. The following fifteen volumes have been planned with an equal balance — and a rather clear separation — between strict history and *Kulturgeschichte*. For instance the second, from the origins of the duchy (*dogado*) of Venice to the Fourth Crusade, will have separate sections on "politics, economics and religion," and on "arts and monuments." The general plan of the work follows similar lines; for instance, the seventh volume will be entirely devoted to political, administrative, and judicial institutions from the time of the creation of the basic *Maggior Consiglio* to the fifteenth century; while the eighth, ninth, and tenth volumes will be respectively devoted to religious institutions, economic history, and literature and the arts up to the Renaissance. The same simple method is followed in the latter part of the plan, with one volume, the fifteenth, devoted to costumes and domestic traditions — presumably an up-to-date substitute for Pompeo Molmenti's now classic history of Venetian private life. The sixteenth and last volume will naturally end with 1866, the year in which Venice was annexed to the kingdom of Italy.

An anthology of Venetian poetry was also overdue. The one by Antonio Pilot (1913) is now hardly satisfactory;

others are even less full and reliable. Francesco Pasinetti's long and loving work in collecting materials for a projected anthology was interrupted by his untimely death. Now Manlio Dazzi's four-volume *Fiore della lirica veneziana*, will be by far the largest and most accurately edited and annotated collection available. The adjective *veneziana* is intended here in the larger sense for which often the word *veneta* is instead used, as in the case of painting (*pittura veneta*); the qualification is important because it means that the poetry includes not only the speech of Venice but also the languages called "rustic" (*rusteghi*), including the *pavano* which is the language of Ruzante and others. The problem, to mention only this one among those handled by Dazzi in his introduction, is interesting also because of the subtle relationship between Venetian poetry and the development of the Italian lyric in general; "rustic" speech may have been a useful reaction to what Dazzi calls *ibridismo italo-veneto*, engendered in such poets as Pisani or Giustinian by the spreading of the Dante and Petrarch cults. At any rate, Dazzi observes, a Venetian poetic speech is consistently to be recognized throughout the long centuries of Venetian cultural history; and even certain distinctive definitions in terms of tone and materials are not in the least unwarranted. Although these first volumes include such relatively major figures as Maffio Venier (1550-

1586) and Antonio Lamberti (1757-1832), the two further volumes will be necessary in order to give some general conclusions their proper perspective. The concluding remarks in Dazzi's introduction are an inviting anticipation: in contrast, of course, to the dreamy, mollified, touristic views of the Venetian temper, the major quality of poetry in the Venetian language is given as "the concrete and fruitful presence of reality," denoting a civilization which is "scaltrita e sorniona insieme, stupefatta e sapiente, letteratissima e mercantile." An inevitable final remark is on the present status of the Venetian language. Far from being dead, as any properly equipped visitor may realize, it is now most usually spoken by Venetians among themselves, of whatever age; all are, of course, bilingual. But more importantly, there is in our time a veritable flourishing of poets in Venetian; the final section of this anthology will probably present some of the most valuable poems in the whole collection, by such contemporary authors as Palmieri, Giotti, and the best of them all, Giacomo Noventa.

It seems, to conclude, that both these works, the *Storia* and the *Fiore*, when completed, will be indispensable in any library that includes Venice and its history and culture; Venice which, in its turn, is one of the inevitable items in any description of civilization as we know it.

[P. M. P.]

THEY "DID WELL"

The author, Lawrence F. Pisani, an associate professor of Sociology, informs the reader that he was led to write his recent book *The Italian in America* (New York: Exposition Press, 1957) by the observation that books about the Italian-Americans are surprisingly scarce on the library shelves of the nation. This does not mean, however, that the subject is entirely new; in fact, the bibliography placed at the end of the volume presents ample evidence that various aspects of his topic had already attracted the attention of numerous writers.

The author starts with the very first trickle of Italian immigration into the United States, and tries to show what contributions were made by the sons of Italy to this country from its very infancy. In the early chapters the author has gathered together a plethora of interesting and often little known information: that one third of Magellan's crew in his voyage around the globe were Italians; that Enrico Tonti was probably the earliest explorer of the Mississippi region; that Giacomo Beltrami probably discovered the source of the Mississippi; that in his quest for the golden city of El Dorado, Coronado sent a Fra Marco da Nizza ahead to test the truth of the Indians' tales about the existence of such a city; that Italian silk workers were brought to the United States to initiate the silk industry; and so on.

Equally interesting are the

passages dealing with the immigration of large groups of Italians, solicited by American agents for the purpose of agricultural colonization in the southern part of the country; the woes of many of these immigrants, and the woes of the industrial laborers who settled in the cities. Woes which can be traced back to many and sundry causes: ignorance of the English language; debts made to secure the passage of other relatives; trade unions which at first were opposed to the introduction of Italian laborers; racial prejudices, etc.

After laying the ground work, as it were, the author proceeds to show how in a relatively short time the Italian immigrants adjusted themselves to the new ways of life of their adopted country, and how, especially in the second and third generations, they rapidly moved up the economic and social ladder. The later chapters deal with such topics as "Italian-American Amusements," "Italian-American Literature," "Artists and Musicians," and "Scientists;" in short, one is conscious of a definite effort to highlight the contribution made by Italo-Americans to that vast canvas which is the American scene.

The subject of Professor Pisani's book is undoubtedly interesting, but its treatment is not entirely satisfactory. Some of the chapters, apparently written in the belief that in numbers there is always strength, are choked by endless lists of Italians who "did well." These lists may actually do the